

The buffalo horns decorating the helmet are made of carved, gilded wood.

The helmet, or *kabuto*, has a leather-covered sweepback to protect the neck.

The throat defense is attached to the mask, or *mempo*, that covers the lower face.

The shoulder guard, or *sode*, is suspended above the arm defense.

The breastplate is decorated with plates of gold lacquer tied with red silk knots.

The arm guard, or *kote*, combines metal plates with chainmail.

Gloves, or *tekko*, are made of small metal plates bound with string.

The skirts, or *kusazuri*, of the armor are split for ease of movement.

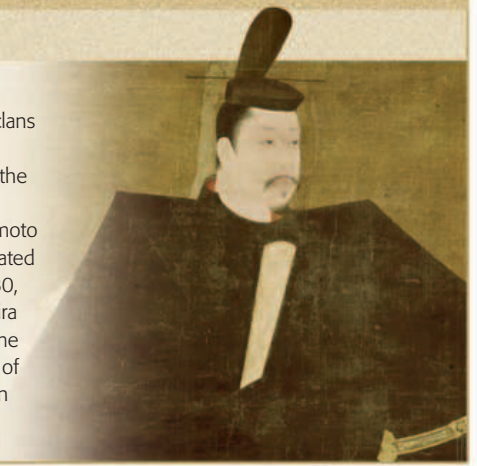
The greaves, or *suneate*, protect the samurai's lower legs.



THE FIRST SHOGUN (1147–99)

MINAMOTO YORITOMO

Minamoto Yoritomo was involved in the feud between the Minamoto and Taira clans from an early age. In 1160 his father, Minamoto Yoshitomo, was executed by the Taira and he was exiled from the capital, Kyoto. Twenty years later he led a Minamoto uprising against the Taira. Although defeated in his first battle at Ishibashiyama in 1180, he went on to triumph both over the Taira and rivals within his own clan. He became shogun in 1192, marking the beginning of Japan's long feudal age. Yoritomo died in a riding accident.



although they were helped by bad weather. For the rest of the time, if the samurai were going to fight, it had to be against one another.

Civil war

In 1333, a major civil war began when the emperor Go Daigo challenged the rule of the shoguns. Aiming to found a new imperial age, in which emperors would exercise real power, with the samurai as their servants, Go Daigo called on warriors across Japan to rise against the shogunate. Many clans were willing to do this, but in order to seize power for themselves, not to restore control to the emperor.

The most ruthless of the samurai, Ashikaga Takauji, expelled Go Daigo from Kyoto and enthroned an alternative emperor, who duly appointed Takauji as the first Ashikaga shogun. Go Daigo set up a rival court at Yoshino and samurai across Japan took up arms in favor of one or other emperor, depending where their personal advantage seemed to lie. The resulting civil war lasted 60 years, before the third Ashikaga shogun, Yoshimitsu, restored peace to Japan in 1392.

Golden age

Ambitious and forceful, Yoshimitsu presided over a golden age of Japanese culture. He made his court at Kyoto the site of a cultural renaissance, patronizing the refined, stylized "Noh" drama (see p.243), collecting ink splash paintings, and promoting Zen, a distinctively Japanese variant on Buddhism that profoundly influenced the arts. Yoshimitsu spent lavishly,

Warrior's armor

Samurai fought without shields, depending on armor for protection. The magnificent helmets and body armor were intended for display as well as defense. This fine example dates from the 19th century, when the samurai had mostly ceased actual fighting.

building a pavilion coated in gold and surrounded by splendid gardens. In 1402 he negotiated formal trade links with the emperor of China, enabling him to import Chinese artifacts for his cultured capital.

Violence erupts again

But Yoshimitsu, and his equally cultured successor, Yoshimasa, presided over an unstable society. The *daimyo*, powerful and brutal warlords who had little allegiance to the shogunate, controlled vast areas in the provinces. While Kyoto practiced refinement, from 1467 Japan descended into permanent civil war between the private armies of rival *daimyo*.

AFTER

In the 16th century, warfare in Japan entered a new era with the introduction of firearms. The fighting finally ended under the shogun Tokugawa Ieyasu, who reunited the country.

CHRISTIANITY

The arrival of Europeans in Japan from 1543 brought both guns and Christianity. A mission established by St. Francis Xavier flourished until the 17th century, when Christianity was banned and converts were persecuted.



ST. FRANCIS XAVIER

UNIFYING JAPAN

In the 16th century, ambitious *daimyo* sought to end Japan's endemic civil strife by unifying the country under a single strong ruler. Odu Nobunaga and his successor Toyotomi Hideyoshi took control of much of Japan in the 1560s–1590s. The unification of the country was completed by Tokugawa Ieyasu 242–43 >>, who became shogun in 1603, founding a dynasty that was to rule for 250 years.